

Environmentalism



Concern for the environment, in the industrialized world at least, had only a small role in philosophy until the 19th century. The Romantic preoccupation with Nature and the American transcendentalist ideal of living in harmony with it, were partly reactions to industrialization, but the idea that humans form only a part of the natural world is also present in the philosophy of Schopenhauer (see [Nietzsche: God is dead](#)). Ideas from the new science of ecology were taken up by philosophers such as Arne Naess, who showed that we have a responsibility for the long-term preservation of a world that does not exist simply for our own benefit. Irresponsible use of

resources reduces their future availability and pollutes the environment, endangering all life including our own. Naess urged us to recognize our relationship to the biosphere and 'think like a mountain', not only to prevent harm to the natural world, but also to live a more meaningful life. His ideas were influential on the growing political Green movement, which gained momentum as the threat of climate change became increasingly difficult to ignore.